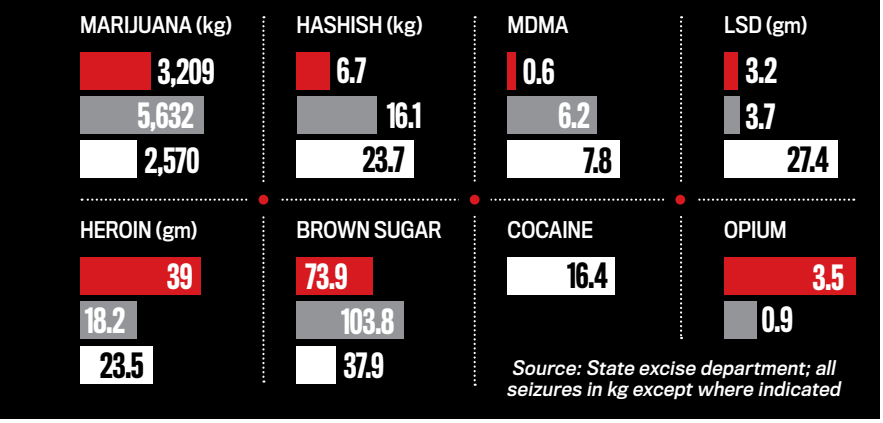


PURPLE HAZE
Officials with a seized consignment of hashish oil in Thrissur in August



Source: State excise department; all seizures in kg except where indicated

killing three people for no reason (in Alappuzha in 2019, women trafficking drugs for pleasure."

Kerala has seen a threefold jump in NDPS cases (16,986 cases with close to 20,000 arrests) till September 15 this year. Kochi and its suburban areas recorded the maximum cases, with police sources claiming they have busted a number of 'kitchen labs' processing synthetic drugs.

But is the state's lax attitude responsible for the current crisis? The intelligence wing says they had filed a report on the spurt in drug abuse cases in 2016, submitting details in the high court. A survey of 400 educational institutions had apparently found that 74 per cent of the schools, 21 per cent of the colleges and 5 per cent of the technical education institutions had seen some level of drug-related offences.

Police blame a loophole in the law (which has since been plugged) for at least marijuana-related cases. For the longest time, seizures below 1 kg were a bailable offence. Kottayam SP K. Karthick, whose department has been doing a lot of outreach work in drugs-related cases, says, "We need to introduce new strategies, scientific methods and specialist cells to hunt down the drug mafia and reform users." Only that will save god's own country. ■

BJP

MAN ON A MISSION

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

After its demoralising setback in the 2021 assembly election, where chief minister Mamata Banerjee held on to her fortress through a massive siege and won a hard-fought battle hands down, the BJP in West Bengal has exhibited all signs of being in trauma ward. Its strategies backfired—142 Trinamool Congress imports it fielded lost in the election, and a reverse flow began. Mukul Roy, former TMC No. 2, did a *ghar wapasi*. Even star MP Babul Supriyo defected. The latter's assembly bypoll win from Ballygunge this April, along with that of Shatrughan Sinha from the Asansol Lok Sabha seat, capped that period of pain. The feud between state unit chief Sukanta Majumdar and Leader of Opposition Suvendu Adhikari, another high-profile Trinamool import, only darkened the gloom.

It's this picture of disarray that a quiet organisational man has now stepped into, with a mandate to set things right well before the big battle of 2024—much like a marshal sent to tame a wild frontier town. Sunil Bansal, newly elevated as BJP national general secretary, has also been entrusted with the charge of two other difficult states besides Bengal: Odisha and Telangana. The party evidently has reason to believe in his ability to master a tough field.

Bansal was seen swinging into action straightaway in Kolkata, as the BJP stirred back to life with the Nabanno Abhiyan this fortnight, its biggest street campaign since the 2021 loss. Several party workers, including leaders like Swapan Dasgupta, were injured in police action against agitators on September 13. Bansal was seen visiting the residences of the injured—the intent was to instil confidence, counter the TMC narrative that the violence was perpetrated by the BJP, and paint it as a case of excess by a politicised police force. Party leaders in New Delhi say the conflict within the party was such